Official Pickleball Rules and Governance (2024)

I. Governance and Evolution

USA Pickleball continues to refine the Official Rulebook to ensure the sport remains fair and consistent as it scales globally. The 2024 edition introduces key clarifications to player conduct, equipment standards, and specific service mechanics to maintain the game's integrity. The USA Pickleball Rules Committee remains the final authority on all rule interpretations and amendments.

II. Court and Equipment Standards

The court dimensions remain fixed at 20 feet by 44 feet ($6.10m \times 13.41m$) for both singles and doubles play. The net height is set at 36 inches at the sidelines and 34 inches at the center. New for 2024 are stricter requirements for paddle surface 'roughness' and 'friction' to prevent excessive spin manipulation. The Non-Volley Zone (NVZ) remains the standard 7-foot area where volleying is strictly prohibited.

III. Service Mechanics and Refinements

Volley Serve Standards

The volley serve must still be hit with an underhand motion, making contact below the waist. The server's arm must move in an upward arc, and the paddle head must be below the wrist.

Drop Serve and Hand Releases

The 2024 rules further clarify the hand release for both volley and drop serves. The ball must be released from the hand without any spin, force, or manipulation. In the drop serve, the ball must be dropped from a height and allowed to bounce naturally; any downward force (a 'dribble' or 'throw') during the release is considered a fault.

IV. Gameplay and Scoring

Side-out scoring remains the standard, where points are only earned by the serving team. The Two-Bounce Rule is fundamental: each side must let the ball bounce once before volleys are permitted. The Non-Volley Zone (NVZ) rules regarding momentum are strictly enforced; touching the NVZ during or immediately after a volley is a fault, regardless of whether the ball is already dead.

V. Conduct and Officiating

The 2024 rulebook introduces expanded sections on 'Player Conduct' and 'Technical Fouls.' This includes stricter penalties for abusive language, paddle abuse, and intentional delays. Players are expected to exhibit the highest levels of sportsmanship, making honest line calls and respecting the decisions of officials in sanctioned play.